

infrastructure and the atmosphere at the students' homes among others, which were responsible for their dismal performance. "Our study confirmed that more than low learning skills, students' familial problems and socio-economic factors were the prime reasons for their poor performance," said M. Sivasankar, director of the department of Public Instruction.

Each of the adopted school was allocated a grant of up to Rs 1 lakh for the year. They used this money to hold

dinner for all Class X students. Taking a cue from this the state Government has announced compulsory noon meal scheme for all classes up to X this year.

"It became clear that the main cause of students' academic backwardness was poverty," said T.K. Narayana Das, member of Palakkad District Panchayat Council which played a significant role in implementing the programme. "It was an eye-opener too. Contrary to popular notion, there are still large sections of children who do

families' poverty."

Sivasankar attributes the success mostly to the collective spirit of students, teachers, parents and the local community. The teachers' contribution was noteworthy with many lending their services voluntarily and often bearing costs on their own. Take the case of K. Balan, head master of Kuttichira Vocational Higher Secondary School, Kozhikode, whose result skyrocketed from an abysmal 8 per cent last year to 75 per cent. Balan used to travel at least 45 km by bus and train from his home, every day to reach the school at six in the morning and return only after nine at night. "We were determined to wrench the school out of the humiliation" he says. The sentiment is echoed by the students too. "We were ridiculed by all as a school of duds. We wanted to prove ourselves," says P. Ershad, the Kuttichira topper.



PASS PER CENT: THEN & NOW

KUTTICHIRA GOVT. SCHOOL, KOZHIKODE

2006: 8 per cent

2007: 75 per cent

KANNAMPADY TRIBAL SCHOOL, IDDUKI

2006: 5 per cent

2007: 63 per cent

ERATTUPETTA HIGH SCHOOL, KOTTAYAM

2006: 8.6 per cent

2007: 72 per cent

REGIONAL FISHERIES SCHOOL, KANNUR

2006: 33 per cent

2007: 100 per cent

PONUNNAM VHSS SCHOOL, KOTTAYAM

2006: 27 per cent

2007: 100 per cent

special classes before and after school hours, mentoring sessions of small group of students by teachers, peer group sessions, tutorials for subjects in which students were particularly weak, counselling sessions for parents, visit by teachers to students' homes and formation of neighbourhood groups by parents to hold evening classes. However, what played the most important role in achieving this success was the provision for special mid-day meal, evening snacks and

not get one good meal a day even in Kerala, which is believed to have eradicated absolute poverty and hunger," says Das, a CPI(M) leader. He says the poorest performance was recorded in schools located in farming villages. V. Ramachandran, education director of Palakkad district points out a gender dimension to the issue despite Kerala's strides in women emancipation. "We found that more girls compared to boys used to come to school empty stomach. They had a larger share in their

The schools also found support, mainly in kind, from several socio-cultural organisations, alumni associations, local panchayats as well. While Kuttichira school received donations, free uniforms, books, provisions, vegetables from local shops and NRI associations like Jeddah Cultural Centre, the local panchayat donated 25 kerosene lamps for the children of VIM school whose homes didn't have electricity.

Despite this support structure, those with means still prefer to send their kids to private schools. The Regional Fisheries Technical School in Kannur even after having bettered its pass percentage to a flawless 100 per cent still sees the strength of its students dipping as most fisher folk with moderate means send their children to the nearby private school.

However, there are many question marks over the Government releasing money this year though Baby has promised to work out a solution. Many panchayats and local organisations have pledged to continue support. But the students are still anxious. Biju, the topper of the Kizhakkanchery school, has dreams in his eyes, while his labourer father looks on with mixed feelings of pride, anxiety and helplessness, his future shrouded in uncertainty.